

From Text Editor to IDE

Not better and worse — a trade between how light the tool is and how much it does for you.

Plain text editor
Notepad, nano
It stores characters.
That is all it does.

Code editor
Notepad++, Sublime
Syntax colouring,
find across files

VS Code
All of the above, plus
debugging, Git, a terminal,
and extensions

Full IDE
IntelliJ, Visual Studio
Deep knowledge of one
language: refactoring,
build tools, analysis

lighter, opens instantly, knows nothing about your code <<----->> heavier, slower to start, understands your code

This course uses VS Code because it sits in the middle: light enough to open for one file, capable enough to debug a real program — and it is free on every operating system.

You will meet all four in a career. Knowing which one a job needs is part of the skill.